

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS IN COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

What do we mean by ethics?

Ethics is a code of thinking and behaviour governed by a combination of personal, moral, legal, and social standards of what is right. Do what is best for everyone under the circumstances. You're not necessarily going to be able to help everyone all the time, but you can try to get as close as possible.

Why is ethical behavior important in community interventions?

- In addition to its simply being the right thing to do, always acting ethically brings some particular advantages with it. It makes your efforts more effective; it cements your standing in the community; it allows you to occupy the moral high ground when arguing the merits of your program, and to exercise moral leadership in the community; and it assures that you remain in good standing legally and professionally.
- **Program effectiveness.** Consistent ethical behavior can lead to a more effective program. Considering ethical principles in all aspects of a community intervention will lead you to finding the most effective and community-centered methods.
- **Standing in the community.** An organization that has a reputation for ethical action is far more likely to be respected by both participants and the community as a whole than one that has been known to be unethical in the past. An organization that's recognized as ethical is also apt to be seen as competent, and to be trusted to treat people with respect and to do what it says it will do. That community trust makes it easier to recruit staff, volunteers, board members, and participants, and to raise money and public support.
- **Moral credibility and leadership.** If you work for the betterment of the world -- whether you see that as social change, social justice, the alleviation of suffering, the fostering of human dignity, or simply the provision of services -- it's consistent to act as you wish the rest of the world to act. Ethical action reflects why you started your community intervention in the first place. You have a moral obligation to yourself, the individuals you work with, and the community to be ethical in all you do, and to expect the same from others. If you fulfill that obligation, and everyone knows it, your voice will have greater impact when you speak out for what you believe is right, or against what you believe is wrong, and others will follow you.

Major ethical considerations for those working in community services include:

1. Harm avoidance

To ensure the service we do is effective, community service providers should have an understanding of the historical contexts of the community they serve before going to volunteer in those places. By understanding and addressing what a community is asking for, one can find the best way to provide support, while avoiding saviorism / "savior complex". When saviorism is a component of service, the service is not aimed at justice or autonomy, but instead becomes a series of solutions that prioritize making the volunteers feel good about themselves. You can avoid causing harm to the client by assessing, minimising and managing risk when planning community activities. Avoiding harm is a key concern for providers of any community service when considering ethical ways of working within the community. There are a number of specific forms of harm that are particularly related to community work:

Harms to avoid

- *Physical harms:* including causing injury, illness, and pain to the client or the employee
- *Psychological harms:* including feelings of worthlessness, distress, guilt, anger or fear related to the provision of the service

- *Devaluation of personal worth*: including being humiliated, manipulated or in other ways treated disrespectfully or unjustly
- *Social harms*: including damage to social networks or relationships with others; discrimination in the access to benefits, services, employment or insurance; and social stigmatisation
- *Economic harms*: including the imposition of direct or indirect costs on participants

2. Power Dynamics

Power dynamics refer to the unequal distribution of resources, influence, and authority among the actors involved in community consultation. Power dynamics can shape who participates, how they participate, and what influence they have on the outcomes. For example, some stakeholders may have more access to information, communication, or funding than others, or some may have more legitimacy or credibility in the eyes of the decision-makers or the community. Don't abuse your position or exploit a participant to gain a personal advantage or to exercise power over another person. This refers to taking advantage of participants or others for political, social, or financial gain. Addressing power dynamics is important, as it aims to create a safe, respectful, and inclusive space for dialogue, where diverse perspectives and interests are recognized and valued, and where power imbalances are acknowledged and mitigated. There are different steps to address power dynamics:

- **Recognize power dynamics**

The first step to address power dynamics is to recognize them. Power dynamics are often invisible, implicit, or normalized, and can be influenced by factors such as race, ethnicity, class, gender, education, culture, language, age, or disability and access to resources. To recognize power dynamics, you need to be aware of your own positionality and privilege, and how they affect your interactions with others. You also need to listen to and learn from the perspectives and experiences of the communities you work with, and acknowledge their expertise and agency.

- **Reflect on power dynamics**

The second step to address power dynamics is to reflect on them. Reflection is a process of critically examining your own assumptions, biases, and actions, and how they impact your outreach goals and outcomes. Reflection can help you to challenge and change your own power and privilege, and to improve your practice and relationships. You can use tools such as journals, feedback, or peer learning to reflect on your own power dynamics, and to seek and incorporate input from others. You can also use tools such as SWOT analysis, logic models, or theories of change to reflect on the power dynamics of your outreach program, and to identify and address any gaps or risks.

- **Respond to power dynamics**

The third step to address power dynamics is to respond to them. Response is a process of taking action to reduce or transform power imbalances, and to foster more inclusive and equitable outreach. Response can involve changing your own behavior and communication style, and adapting your outreach strategies and methods. You can use tools such as codes of conduct, ground rules, or agreements to establish clear and respectful expectations and boundaries for your outreach. You can also use tools such as co-design, co-implementation, or co-evaluation to share power and decision-making with the communities you work with, and to ensure their participation and ownership of your outreach.

- **Learn from power dynamics**

The fourth step to address power dynamics is to learn from them. Learning is a process of continuously monitoring and evaluating your outreach activities and outcomes, and using the findings to improve your practice and impact. Learning can help you to measure and

demonstrate your social impact, and to identify and celebrate your successes and challenges. You can use tools such as surveys, interviews, or focus groups to collect and analyze data from your outreach. You can also use tools such as stories, case studies, or reports to communicate and disseminate your learning to others.

- **Share power dynamics**

The fifth step to address power dynamics is to share them. Sharing is a process of engaging and collaborating with other actors and stakeholders who are involved or interested in your outreach. Sharing can help you to build trust and rapport, and to create and leverage synergies and opportunities. You can use tools such as newsletters, social media, or events to inform and update others about your outreach. You can also use tools such as networks, partnerships, or coalitions to connect and coordinate with others who share your vision and values.

- **Challenge power dynamics**

The sixth and final step to address power dynamics is to challenge them. Challenging is a process of advocating and influencing for systemic and structural changes that can support and sustain your outreach. Challenging can help you to amplify your voice and impact, and to contribute to social justice and transformation. You can use tools such as campaigns, petitions, or lobbying to raise awareness and mobilize action for your outreach. You can also use tools such as policy, research, or innovation to generate and share evidence and solutions for your outreach.

3. **Cultural Sensitivity**

To be culturally sensitive means you do not believe one culture is superior to another. In other words, you recognize differences without assigning a specific value to any one culture. One culture is not good or bad, right or wrong, positive or negative or better or worse than another. They are simply different.

Dr. Milton J. Bennett developed the Bennett Scale, also called the Developmental Model of Intercultural Sensitivity (DMIS). The Bennett Scale describes the ways people react to cultural differences. The six stages of cultural sensitivity are:

- **STAGE 1. Denial of difference:** Do not recognize cultural differences and believe the only “real” culture is their own. At this stage people tend to stay in homogeneous groups (societies composed of people who are alike, often of the same race) and stereotype everyone else.
- **STAGE 2. Defense of difference:** Recognize some differences they believe to be negative since the differences are not like their culture.
- **STAGE 3. Minimization of difference:** More aware of differences but unaware that they are projecting what they believe are superior values about the differences.
- **STAGE 4. Acceptance of difference:** Can shift perspective and understand “ordinary” behavior can have different meaning in each culture.
- **STAGE 5. Adaptation of difference:** Become more competent in communicating with other cultures and can adapt behavior to fit the differences in cultures and use empathy. Empathy is understanding or feeling what the other person is experiencing.
- **STAGE 6. Integration of difference:** Are culturally sensitive and have empathy for other cultures. This person is often bilingual (able to speak two languages easily) and bicultural (combining the cultural attitudes and customs of two distinct groups, often one’s own culture and that of another) and equally comfortable in either culture.

As a community service provider, one should try to:

- Recognize and value diversity.

- Continually assess internal behaviors, policies, and processes that may be creating or contributing to unconscious biases.
- Be consciously aware of cultural dynamics and interactions within the organization or between employees and customers.
- Make every effort to be inclusive of other cultures and to adapt services to best meet the needs of diverse cultures.

4. Competency

It's important to distinguish between doing what you can and getting in over your head to the point where what you're doing becomes truly unethical and harmful. Going in community after gaining proper knowledge, skill and training is helpful. Don't attempt an intervention in areas in which you're not trained and/or competent. Actively strive to improve or correct, to the extent possible, the situations of participants in your program and the community. In other words, it's incumbent on you to try to create the best and most effective program possible to meet the needs of participants, and to address underlying conditions or situations in a way that will benefit the community as a whole.

5. Consent

Another aspect of ensuring that community workers behave ethically is ensuring that participants give consent to participate in community activities. The consent should be a voluntary choice based on sufficient information and an understanding of outcomes and the implications of participation.

6. Privacy and Confidentiality

When collecting any data or personal information as part of the community, it is important to maintain the privacy and confidentiality of individuals and communities. Be transparent about the limits of confidentiality in the professional practice. You may have access to information, you may overhear or view situations, or someone from outside wants to know what is happening inside your organization. Maintain confidentiality in such cases.

7. Conflict of Interest

A conflict of interest is a situation in which someone's personal (financial, political, professional, social, family, etc.) interests could influence his judgment or actions in a financial or other decision, in carrying out his job, or in his relationships with participants. In community interventions, conflicts of interest may change -- to the community's disadvantage -- how a program is run or how its money is spent.

8. Responsible use of resources

In order to effectively utilise resources for community development, it is important to understand the role that resources play. Resources can be physical, such as land, buildings, or equipment; or intangible, such as knowledge, skills, or funds. They can also be natural or man-made, and may include both public and private resources. By understanding the role of each type of resource, it is possible to identify which resources are available and how they can be used to support community development. In addition to understanding the role of resources, it is also important to consider how resources can be used to create positive change in the community. This may involve developing strategies to increase access to resources, or to ensure that resources are used in a way that benefits the community. It is also important to consider how resources can be used to promote collaboration and cooperation between different stakeholders in the community, in order to ensure that the community is able to reach its development goals.

Once the role of resources has been established, the next step is to identify what resources are available to support community development. This involves researching the local area to see what resources are accessible, such as public parks or community centres. It also involves looking at existing private resources, such as businesses or private foundations, that may be willing to partner

with the community. By identifying these resources it is possible to develop a plan to maximise their impact on community development.

In order to ensure that resources are used efficiently, it is important to create a plan that outlines how the resources will be allocated and used. This plan should include a timeline for implementation, as well as a budget for the resources. Additionally, it is important to monitor the progress of the plan and make adjustments as needed. Finally, it is important to evaluate the effectiveness of the plan and make changes as necessary to ensure that the resources are being used in the most effective way possible.

9. Reporting Relevant Issues or Unethical Organizational Behavior

Community service providers must notify their home department of any issue that might affect their ability to perform their functions or cause harm to themselves or others.

They must also report organizational behavior that fails to comply with ethical criteria, including unlawful conduct (of directors, paid workers or other volunteers), using the organization's proper channels.

10. Refusal to Accept Benefits

Community service providers should not receive benefits in any form from the organization's clients or any other persons. It can be gifts or any other form of benefit.

11. Promoting Social Justice

Uphold the principles of social justice related to the rights of individuals, families, groups, organizations, and communities to receive fair and equitable access to services, resources, and opportunities. Promote environment free from oppression, racism, and discrimination. Must respect clients, treat them in a dignified, responsible, patient and tolerant manner, refrain from discriminating or biased treatment of clients, and respect individual differences and people equally without prejudice or favour.

12. Valuing Human Relationships and respecting the dignity and worth of all people

Place the well-being and interests of all people at the center of relationships. Continually develop self-awareness and practice self-reflection to guide the practice and personal well-being. Build relationships based on mutual respect and place the public interest over personal interest. Promote the self-determination and autonomy of all people. Respect the status, rights, diversity and needs of all people living in community. Uphold the rights of every person, group, and community to be free from violence or threat of violence. Respect people as ends, not means: Consider and treat everyone as a unique individual who matters, not as a number in a political or social or clinical calculation. Respect participants' ability to play a role in determining what they need. Don't assume that professional staff or program planners necessarily know what's best for a community or individual. Respect everyone's human, civil, and legal rights. This encompasses such issues as non-discrimination and cultural sensitivity.

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CIVIC DUTY

A set of obligations citizens are expected to fulfill throughout their lives is called civic duty. Civic duties are divided into two categories - obligations and responsibilities.

1. **Civic obligation** is a requirement by law. These are actions citizens must take to participate in society and avoid legal repercussions.

- **Jury Duty**

Individuals charged with a crime have the constitutional right to a speedy and fair trial before a jury of peers. It, therefore, becomes the responsibility of citizens to fulfill this role. Prospective jurors are issued a summons that calls them to the court for an interview. Not everyone summoned for jury duty will serve. But all citizens 18 and older must participate if called upon.

- **Obeying the Law**

Citizens must follow federal, state, and local laws and abide by the Constitution.

Examples:

- Obeying traffic signals. By complying with road regulations, citizens keep themselves out of danger and protect others.
- A citizen has a civic obligation, for instance, not to work as a spy for another country against your home country.

- **Taxes:**

Citizens are responsible for reporting their income to the Federal Board of Revenue (FBR) and paying federal, state, and local taxes. Tax collection keeps the government up and running and pays for essential services like clean water, paved roads, schools, and the police and fire departments.

Some civic duties and responsibilities extend to every community member, regardless if they are citizens. Everyone must obey laws and pay taxes, while voting and jury duty is reserved for citizens.

2. **Civic Responsibility** is not necessarily in the law but is expected of every citizen or resident of an area. Though not mandatory yet important for all citizens to get involved.

- **Voting**

- In some countries, voting is a civic obligation. However, it is critically important right for all citizens 18 and older.
- The first step is registering to vote, but civic responsibility doesn't end at the ballot box.
- It requires a commitment to learning about candidates and policy initiatives, staying informed about important issues, and educating oneself to make informed decisions.
- It includes being politically aware, researching and questioning political candidates, and other matters arising during elections to make meaningful decisions.

- **Sharing Concerns and Opinions:** An essential component of democracy is citizens' ability to articulate their opinions and voice any concerns they have. An example is contacting the city about a troublesome pothole or a downed power line so it can be repaired.

- **Respect Across Differences:** Democratic societies are composed of people who hold diverse beliefs. So citizens must be accepting of those who may not share their same views.

- **Community Service**

- Getting involved in the community can take many forms.
- There are limitless possibilities to suit a variety of interests.

- All of these involvements show citizens' commitment to their respective communities. Community service also conveys that we all have a role in improving our society.

Examples include:

- Respecting and being polite with one another
- Helping fellow human beings in times of difficulty
- Showing consideration to the elderly, women, children and disabled people
- Respecting minorities
- Using the public facilities with utmost care
- Keeping the environment clean
- Switching off electric appliances where not required
- Saving water
- Volunteering for a better cause
- Giving donations
- Planting more trees
- Following traffic rules
- Obeying rules while you are being observed or not
- Parking on right place
- Stopping or reporting water leakage

Importance of Civic responsibilities

- **It promotes a sense of community:** When citizens actively participate in their communities, they feel a sense of ownership and belonging. This promotes a stronger sense of community and can help create a more cohesive society.
- **It strengthens democracy:** Democracy depends on citizens who are informed and engaged. When citizens participate in the democratic process, they help to ensure that the government represents their interests and reflects their values.
- **It helps us understand and address social issues:** By volunteering and contributing to their communities, citizens can help address social issues such as poverty, homelessness, and inequality.
- **It helps us be informed and active citizens:** When we know our rights and duties as citizens, we can participate in our government more effectively. We can also work to make our government more responsive to the needs of its people.
- **Promotes social justice:** Civic responsibility motivates individuals to contribute towards betterment of society by fairness and justice. By tackling social issues and striving for systemic change, citizens can contribute to building a more just society.
- **Personal Growth:** Personal growth in civic responsibility involves increasing awareness of social issues, developing empathy and ethical values, enhancing critical thinking and communication skills, and actively participating in civic activities such as volunteering and advocacy. This process leads to a deeper sense of purpose, personal empowerment, and the ability to contribute positively to the community and society.